Financial Readiness Course

INSTRUCTOR GUIDE

Veterans Upward Bound (VUB) - West Virginia

📅 Single-Session Workshop ⏱️ 2.5 - 3 Hours 👥 Veterans Group 📍 Computer Lab

💻 5 Modules, 58 Slides, 5 Handouts

🎯 Course Purpose

This workshop delivers financial literacy and retirement planning education specifically tailored for military veterans. The course covers the full retirement landscape: transition timelines, disability compensation, healthcare integration, investment protection, and legacy planning.

Format: Instructor-led presentation using the web-based slide system. Each module is self-contained with its own chapter navigation, progress tracking, and completion celebration. The application runs locally with no internet required for core content.

🗺 Course Module Map

MODULE 1

Retirement Timelines & Preparation

BDD claims, BRS, DD-214, retirement pay, TSP, TAP resources

12 slides + handout

MODULE 2

Disability Pay & Compensation

VA Waiver, CRDP vs CRSC, Social Security interaction

10 slides + handout

MODULE 3

Healthcare & Long-Term Care

VA healthcare, Medicare/TRICARE for Life, CHAMPVA, Aid & Attendance

13 slides + handout

MODULE 4

Investment Risks & Taxes

Sequence risk, bucket strategy, 4% rule, income stacking, state taxes

11 slides + handout

MODULE 5

Legacy Planning

SBP, DIC, estate planning, VA burial, beneficiary designations

12 slides + handout

⏰ Session Timeline (2.5 - 3 Hours)

0:00 - 0:10

Welcome & Introduction WARM-UP

Introduce yourself and the course. Ask participants about their service branch and retirement status. Set expectations: this is education, not personal financial advice. Distribute any printed materials.

0:10 - 0:35

Module 1: Retirement Timelines PRESENTATION

Walk through the 12 slides covering military transition, retirement pay, TSP, and transition resources. Distribute the Retirement Transition Checklist handout at the start.

- Emphasize the 90-180 day BDD filing window
- Walk through the retirement pay calculation (High-3 vs BRS)
- Cover all 5 TSP fund options and withdrawal rules
- Highlight TAP and VSO resources

0:35 - 0:45

Module 1 Discussion DISCUSSION

"How many of you have already gone through your transition? What was the hardest part administratively?" Let veterans share experiences. Those who have been through it can mentor those who haven't.

0:45 - 1:10

Module 2: Disability Compensation PRESENTATION

Cover the VA Waiver, CRDP vs CRSC comparison, annual election, and Social Security interaction. This is the most complex module -- go slowly through the side-by-side comparison slide.

- Use the stat cards to make dollar-for-dollar offset concrete
- Clarify that CRDP is automatic, CRSC requires DD 2860
- Stress: VA disability does NOT reduce Social Security

1:10 - 1:20

Break BREAK

10-minute break. Encourage participants to write down any questions that came up during Modules 1-2. Offer to answer individual questions during break.

1:20 - 1:45

Module 3: Healthcare & Long-Term Care PRESENTATION

Cover Medicare enrollment at 65, TRICARE for Life coordination, and Aid & Attendance. The 2026 A&A rates are a highlight -- many veterans don't know this benefit exists.

- Emphasize: Medicare Parts A & B required to keep TRICARE for Life
- TRICARE for Life = Medicare pays first, TRICARE covers the rest
- Aid & Attendance net worth limit: $163,699 (2026)

Module 4: Investment Risks & Taxes PRESENTATION

1:45 - 2:05	Explain sequence of returns risk with a concrete example. Walk through the three-bucket strategy. Cover state tax treatment and the hidden costs warning (property taxes, insurance). > Use the bucket icons to make the strategy visual and memorable > The state tax map is a great discussion starter > Remind: VA disability is tax-free at federal AND state levels
2:05 - 2:15	**Module 4 Discussion** DISCUSSION "Has anyone here considered relocating in retirement for tax reasons? What other factors did you weigh?" This is often a lively discussion -- veterans have strong opinions about where to retire.
2:15 - 2:35	**Module 5: Legacy Planning** PRESENTATION Cover SBP overview, premiums, pros and cons, DIC interaction, and financial modeling recommendation. This is the most personal module -- be sensitive to the topic of end-of-life planning. > Stress the irrevocable nature of the SBP election > The pros/cons slides are great for structured comparison > End with the financial advisor recommendation
2:35 - 2:50	**Course Review & Study Resources** REVIEW Navigate to the Study Resources section. Show the quiz and flashcards. Walk through one quiz question as an example. Point out the podcast, study guide, and infographic for at-home review. > Open the quiz to show the format (10 multiple-choice questions) > Demonstrate one flashcard flip > Mention the audio overview for those who prefer listening
2:50 - 3:00	**Q&A and Wrap-Up** APPLICATION Open the floor for final questions. Summarize the three most important takeaways. Remind participants of the financial advisor disclaimer. Thank them for their service and participation.

📚 Module Teaching Notes

🎖️ Module 1: Retirement Timelines & Preparation

📄 12 slides ⏱️ ~25 min presentation + 10 min discussion 📋 5 chapters

Key Concepts to Emphasize

> **BDD Claims (90-180 days):** This is the single most time-sensitive action. Missing this window means filing a standard claim post-separation, which takes months longer.

> **DD Form 214:** The foundation document for ALL future benefits. Errors are extremely difficult to correct after the fact.

> **BRS Lump-Sum Decision:** This is irrevocable. Veterans must model the financial impact before choosing between the lump sum and full monthly annuity.

> **6-Month Checklist:** Physicals, BDD claims, relocation request, outprocessing -- all on strict deadlines.

Common Questions

> "I already separated years ago -- is BDD relevant?" No, but understanding the standard claims process is. Direct them to VA.gov.

> "Can I get a copy of my DD-214?" Yes -- through the National Personnel Records Center (NPRC) or eVetRecs online.

⚖️ Module 2: Disability Pay & Compensation

📄 10 slides ⏱️ ~25 min presentation 📋 5 chapters

Key Concepts to Emphasize

> **VA Waiver:** Dollar-for-dollar offset is the foundation of everything else in this module. Make sure they understand this before moving on.

> **CRDP vs CRSC:** The side-by-side comparison is the most important slide. Pause here and let them absorb both columns.

> **Tax Difference:** CRDP = taxable, CRSC = non-taxable. For some veterans this difference is thousands of dollars per year.

> **Annual Election:** Veterans who qualify for both should run the numbers every year -- rating changes can shift which program pays more.

Common Questions

> "How do I know if I qualify for CRSC?" You need combat-related disabilities. File DD 2860 with your service branch -- they determine the combat nexus.

> "Will my VA disability affect my Social Security?" No. VA disability compensation is completely separate and does not reduce SS benefits.

🩹 Module 3: Healthcare & Long-Term Care

📄 13 slides ⏱️ ~25 min presentation 📋 5 chapters

Key Concepts to Emphasize

> **Medicare at 65:** Veterans MUST enroll in Medicare Parts A & B at 65 to keep TRICARE for Life. Late enrollment = permanently higher premiums.

> **TRICARE for Life:** It's a wraparound -- Medicare pays first, TRICARE covers the rest. This is one of the best health benefits available.

> **Medicare Part D vs VA Pharmacy:** VA drug coverage is comprehensive but requires VA pharmacies. Part D offers local pharmacy flexibility.

> **Aid & Attendance:** Many veterans don't know this exists. The 2026 rates ($2,424-$3,845/month) are significant. Highlight the 3-year look-back on asset transfers.

Common Questions

> "Do I need Medicare if I have VA healthcare?" VA healthcare covers VA facilities. Medicare gives you access to any Medicare-accepting provider. Most veterans benefit from having both.

> "What's the net worth limit for A&A?" $163,699 in 2026. This includes most assets except primary residence and personal vehicle.

📈 Module 4: Investment Risks & Taxes

📄 11 slides ⏱️ ~25 min presentation + 10 min discussion 📋 6 chapters

Key Concepts to Emphasize

> **Sequence of Returns:** Use the concrete example: a 15% drop in year 1 vs year 10 has dramatically different outcomes. This is not about average returns -- it's about timing.

> **Bucket Strategy:** Liquidity (1-5 yrs), Lifestyle (3-10 yrs), Legacy (10+ yrs). The key insight: never sell from the Legacy bucket during a downturn.

> **State Tax Map:** 9 states with no income tax. But warn about hidden costs -- Florida and Texas have high property taxes and insurance.

> **DTI Impact:** Tax-free income increases VA loan buying power. This connects military benefits to practical homebuying decisions.

Common Questions

> "Should I move to a no-tax state?" It depends on total cost of living. Property taxes, insurance, and cost of housing can offset the savings. Encourage them to do the full calculation.

> "What about my TSP?" TSP withdrawals are taxable. The bucket strategy applies to how they draw from TSP alongside other income sources.

🌱 Module 5: Legacy Planning

📄 12 slides ⏱ ~25 min presentation 📋 5 chapters

Key Concepts to Emphasize

- **SBP = 55%:** Surviving beneficiary receives 55% of the selected base amount. It's inflation-indexed and guaranteed for life.
- **Irrevocable:** The SBP election (or declination) via DD Form 2656 cannot be changed. Declining requires spouse's notarized signature.
- **Paid-Up Status:** 360 months of premiums AND age 70. Both conditions must be met -- this surprises many retirees.
- **DIC Offset:** If DIC applies, it may offset SBP payments. This is a nuance that trips up many families.

Sensitivity Note

- Legacy planning involves discussing death and the financial impact on surviving family. Be direct but compassionate.
- Some participants may have already lost spouses or may be going through difficult family situations. Be aware of the room.
- Close with the financial advisor recommendation -- emphasize that every family's situation is unique.

💬 Discussion Questions by Module

Module 1 - Opener:

"How many of you have already separated or retired? What was the most confusing part of the administrative process?"

Module 2 - After CRDP/CRSC Comparison:

"Has anyone here dealt with the DFAS lag after a rating change? What happened?"

Module 3 - Medicare Section:

"How many of you are already enrolled in Medicare? Did you know TRICARE for Life covers what Medicare doesn't?"

Module 4 - State Tax Map:

"Has anyone relocated or considered relocating for tax reasons? What factors did you weigh beyond income tax?"

Module 5 - After SBP Pros/Cons:

"For those who elected SBP -- looking back, are you glad you did? What would you tell someone who hasn't decided yet?"

Wrap-Up:

"What's one thing you learned today that you wish you had known earlier in your career?"

📝 Instructor Notes

- **Pacing:** The timeline is designed for 2.5-3 hours. If short on time, abbreviate the Module 4 discussion and reduce the Study Resources walkthrough. Modules 1-3 are the highest priority.
- **Experience Levels:** Some participants will be pre-retirement, others decades into it. Use the experienced veterans as informal mentors -- their real-world stories reinforce the material.
- **Financial Advice Boundary:** You are educating, not advising. When asked "should I do X?" redirect to "here are the factors to consider, and I'd recommend talking to a financial advisor about your specific situation."
- **Emotional Topics:** Disability ratings, end-of-life planning, and VA frustrations can be emotional. Acknowledge feelings, don't rush past them, and keep the tone respectful.
- **Acronym Overload:** This course is acronym-heavy (BDD, BRS, CRDP, CRSC, SBP, DIC). The slides define each on first use, but repeat the full name when participants look confused.
- **Dark Mode:** The presentation supports dark mode via the theme toggle in the sidebar. If the projector washes out the light theme, switch to dark mode for better contrast.

📦 Materials Checklist

TECHNOLOGY

- ☐ Projector connected & working
- ☐ Browser open to index.html
- ☐ Test all 5 module presentations
- ☐ Verify dark/light mode toggle
- ☐ Test keyboard navigation (arrows)

STUDY RESOURCES

- ☐ Quiz loads (quiz.html)
- ☐ Flashcards load (flashcards.html)
- ☐ Podcast plays (MP3 file)
- ☐ Infographic displays
- ☐ Study guide accessible

HANDOUTS (PRINT)

- ☐ Retirement Transition Checklist
- ☐ CRDP vs CRSC Comparison
- ☐ Healthcare Benefits Reference
- ☐ TSP & Retirement Income Worksheet
- ☐ SBP Decision Worksheet

CLASSROOM

- ☐ Workstations powered on
- ☐ Course URL on each screen
- ☐ Whiteboard/markers available
- ☐ Water and refreshments for break

✓ Tips for Success

- ✓ Open with respect for their service -- this audience values directness and authenticity
- ✓ Use the presentation sidebar to jump between slides if a question pulls you ahead
- ✓ When a veteran shares a personal story, connect it back to the content: "That's exactly what this slide covers"
- ✓ The completion celebrations (confetti) at the end of each module add levity -- let them enjoy it
- ✓ Encourage participants to bookmark the course on their lab computers for self-study after class
- ✓ The flashcards and quiz are great for a quick review at the end if time permits
- ✓ If a question gets too specific ("Should I elect CRSC?"), redirect: "That depends on your specific rating and combat history -- let's talk after class or connect you with a VSO"

⚠ Content Cautions

- ⚠ **Not Financial Advice:** This course provides education, not personalized recommendations. Always direct specific questions to a qualified financial advisor, tax professional, or attorney.
- ⚠ **Benefit Amounts Change:** Dollar amounts, net worth limits, and rates cited are for 2026 and may change with annual COLA adjustments.
- ⚠ **State Tax Laws Evolve:** The state tax landscape changes frequently. Encourage participants to verify current laws for their specific state before making relocation decisions.
- ⚠ **No Investment Recommendations:** Never recommend specific investment products, funds, or financial advisors. Point participants to VA.gov, DFAS.mil, or their local Veterans Service Organization (VSO).

Official Resources for Referrals

- **VA.gov** -- Claims, benefits, healthcare enrollment
- **DFAS.mil** -- Military retired pay, CRDP/CRSC, myPay portal
- **TRICARE.mil** -- TRICARE for Life enrollment and plan details
- **SSA.gov** -- Social Security benefits, earnings record, retirement estimator
- **Medicare.gov** -- Enrollment, plan comparison, Part D options
- **TSP.gov** -- Thrift Savings Plan account management, withdrawal options
- **Local VSO** -- Free claims assistance, benefits counseling, advocacy